

Haligric Research Integration Series

SHAMANISM

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Siberian Origins, South American Plant Traditions, and Korean Muism

*"The shaman knows that the world is alive.
Everything is alive. Everything is conscious.
Everything is willing to communicate
with the being who approaches it in the right way."
— Teaching of multiple shamanic traditions*

Contents

Introduction — The Oldest Technology of Consciousness.....	3
What Shamanism Is — The Core Defining Features.....	4
The Three Worlds — Upper, Middle, and Lower.....	5
The World Tree / Axis Mundi.....	6
The Shamanic Journey — Mechanics and Method.....	7
Soul Retrieval — The Central Healing Technology.....	8
Spirit Animals / Power Animals.....	9
The Shamanic Calling — Illness, Crisis, and Election.....	10
Siberian Shamanism — The Original Tradition.....	11
Tungus and Evenki Shamanism — The Source.....	12
The Siberian Shaman's Costume — A Cosmos Worn.....	00
The Drum — The Shaman's Horse.....	00
Yakut and Buryat Shamanism.....	15
Mongolian Shamanism — Tengerism.....	16
South American Shamanism — The Plant Teachers.....	17
Shipibo Curanderismo — Song as Healing Technology.....	18
The Icaros — Sacred Songs of the Amazon.....	19
Ayahuasca — The Vine of Souls.....	20
The Andean Tradition — Paqos, Apus, and the Living Cosmos.....	21
Huachuma / San Pedro — The Grandfather Cactus.....	22
Korean Muism — The Female Shamanic Tradition.....	23
The Mudang — Korea's Female Shamans.....	00
The Gut — The Korean Shamanic Ceremony.....	25
The Spirits of Korean Muism.....	26
Soul Retrieval Across Traditions — A Comparative Map.....	27
The Haligric Ancestor Altar and Shamanic Practice.....	28
The Haligricity Lens — Non-Ordinary Reality and the Living Altar.....	29

Introduction

The Oldest Technology of Consciousness

Shamanism is the oldest technology of consciousness available to the human species — predating all the world's organized religions, predating writing, predating civilization in any formal sense, present in the archaeological record from at least 40,000 years ago. Cave paintings at Altamira (Spain, 36,000 BCE), Chauvet (France, 30,000 BCE), and Lascaux (France, 17,000 BCE) — therianthropic figures (human-animal hybrids suggesting shamanic transformation), geometric patterns identical to entoptic phenomena seen in altered states, and the deep inaccessible chambers that function as ritual initiation spaces — constitute the oldest evidence of the technology this guide documents. Every tradition in the Haligricity library, including the most sophisticated philosophical systems of India, China, and Greece, has roots that ultimately reach back to the shamanic layer of human sacred experience.

This guide covers three specific shamanic traditions in depth — chosen because they represent three distinct regional expressions of the universal shamanic pattern, and because each offers specific gifts directly relevant to Haligric practice: Siberian shamanism (the etymological and probably historical source of the word "shaman," and the most completely documented original form), South American shamanism (home to the world's most sophisticated plant-medicine healing traditions and to the Amazonian curanderismo that has produced the specific healing songs called icaros), and Korean Muism (one of the world's oldest continuous shamanic traditions, practiced primarily by female shamans called mudang).

What Shamanism Is

The Core Defining Features

The word "shaman" comes from the Tungus (Evenki) word šaman — referring to the specific type of ritual specialist found among the indigenous peoples of Siberia who enters specific states of altered consciousness (trance) to interact with spirits on behalf of the community. Mircea Eliade's 1951 study *Shamanism: Archaic Techniques of Ecstasy* established the comparative framework through which the commonalities across diverse indigenous traditions came to be understood as expressions of a single fundamental pattern.

1. THE SHAMAN SPECIALIZES IN NON-ORDINARY STATES OF

CONSCIOUSNESS: Deliberately entered, not passive or accidental — the shaman trains to navigate altered states of consciousness with specific intentionality.

2. THE SHAMAN INTERACTS WITH SPIRITS: The non-ordinary reality the shaman navigates is populated by specific beings — ancestral spirits, nature spirits, helping spirits, illness spirits — with whom the shaman develops working relationships.

3. THE SHAMAN ACTS ON BEHALF OF THE COMMUNITY: Shamanism is fundamentally a community service — the shaman's navigation of non-ordinary reality is for the purpose of healing, divination, and guidance for specific community members and the community as a whole.

4. THE SHAMAN MEDIATES BETWEEN WORLDS: The shaman occupies the boundary between ordinary and non-ordinary reality — capable of moving between them in ways that ordinary community members cannot.

5. HEALING IS CENTRAL: The primary function of shamanic practice in virtually every tradition is healing — physical illness, psychological distress, community disruption, and the specific condition of soul loss.

6. SPECIFIC TECHNIQUES: The shamanic journey (deliberate trance travel to non-ordinary reality), soul retrieval (the recovery of lost soul-parts), power animal retrieval, extraction (removing intrusive spiritual elements), and psychopomp work (guiding the dead) are found across diverse traditions with remarkable consistency.

7. THE SHAMAN IS CALLED, NOT CHOSEN: Shamans across traditions are not volunteers — they are called by the spirits through specific experiences (often including serious illness, near-death, crisis) that leave them no choice but to accept the vocation or suffer the consequences.

The Three Worlds

The Universal Shamanic Cosmological Map

Across the extraordinary diversity of shamanic traditions, a consistent cosmological structure appears: the universe is organized into three worlds, connected by a central axis, and navigable by the trained practitioner.

THE UPPER WORLD: The realm above — typically reached by ascending through or above the sky (up a tree, up a rainbow, through a smoke hole, into the clouds and beyond). Generally associated with higher spiritual beings (deities, angels, cosmic forces), ancestors who have ascended to higher spiritual states, and future knowledge and broad cosmic perspective. The upper world tends to have a quality of luminosity and expansiveness.

THE MIDDLE WORLD: The world of ordinary everyday reality — but understood as also containing its non-ordinary dimension. The spirits of nature inhabit the middle world: the spirits of specific trees, specific rivers, specific stones, specific places, specific animals in the wild. The middle world is also where the wandering dead may be found — those who have died but not fully transitioned to another state.

THE LOWER WORLD: The realm below — typically reached by descending through an opening in the earth (a tree root, a cave, a lake, a hole in the ground). Despite the name, the lower world is not the equivalent of hell in the Abrahamic sense. It is generally understood as the realm of earth spirits and nature powers, the home of power animals and totemic helpers, the source of grounded earthly wisdom. Most shamanic healing work (particularly soul retrieval and power animal retrieval) is done in the lower world.

THE BOUNDARY BETWEEN WORLDS: The three worlds are separated by membranes or boundaries that ordinary consciousness cannot cross. The shaman's primary skill is the trained capacity to cross these boundaries consciously and with intentionality.

The World Tree / Axis Mundi

The Connection Between Worlds

The World Tree (in Siberian traditions, the Cosmic Tree — in Norse mythology, Yggdrasil; in Mesoamerican traditions, the Ceiba; in various traditions, the Mountain, the Pole, the Cosmic Pillar) is the axis mundi — the central axis that connects the three worlds, the specific point where movement between worlds is most accessible, and the structure along which the shaman climbs upward to the upper world or descends to the lower.

The World Tree appears in virtually every shamanic tradition in the world: the Siberian shaman climbs the World Tree in trance; the Tungus shaman's drum is made from the wood of the World Tree; the Norse god Odin hung on Yggdrasil (the World Tree) for nine days to receive the runes; the Mayan Ceiba tree connects the underworld through its roots, the earth world in its trunk, and the heavens in its branches; the Hindu Mount Meru and the Buddhist cosmic mountain serve the same cosmological function; the Kabbalistic Tree of Life maps the same structure onto the human soul.

The Shamanic Journey

Mechanics and Method

The shamanic journey — the deliberate entry into an altered state of consciousness to navigate non-ordinary reality — is the fundamental shamanic technology. It is not a vision or a hallucination in the passive sense; it is a directed navigation of non-ordinary reality with specific intention, specific destination, and specific purpose.

THE INTENTION: Before beginning the journey, the shaman sets a specific clear intention — "I am going to the lower world to find [this person's] power animal" or "I am going to the upper world to ask my teacher about [this situation]." The journey is purposeful, not exploratory.

THE VEHICLE: The most universal shamanic induction method is rhythmic sound — typically the drum, though rattles, singing, and other sound instruments also serve. The specific drumming rhythm most used in core shamanic practice is approximately 200 beats per minute — a theta-wave-inducing rhythm (4-7 beats per second) that facilitates the specific state of consciousness in which journeying occurs.

THE ENTRY POINT: The shaman enters the journey through a specific imagined entry point — a particular hole in the ground, a cave, a tree root, or a lake for lower world journeys; a rainbow, a tall tree, or a mountain peak for upper world journeys.

THE JOURNEY ITSELF: In the altered state, the shaman experiences non-ordinary reality with the same sensory vividness as ordinary reality — seeing, hearing, feeling, and sometimes smelling and tasting. The spirits encountered are not passive images; they communicate, they resist, they have their own agendas and their own knowledge.

THE RETURN: When the work is complete, the shaman returns to the entry point and ascends back to the ordinary world. The specific drumming pattern shifts (often to a callback rhythm — rapid double-beat drumming) to signal the return.

THE INTEGRATION: What the shaman brings back — information, power, soul fragments, power animals — is applied to the specific healing or guidance need that motivated the journey. The integration of the journey's results into the ordinary world is as important as the journey itself.

Soul Retrieval

The Central Healing Technology

Soul retrieval is the most distinctively shamanic of all healing practices — the specific shamanic technology for recovering parts of the soul that have been lost through trauma, shock, or chronic distress. In the shamanic view, when a human being experiences overwhelming trauma, a part of the soul leaves the body — a protective dissociation that is understood as a spiritual reality rather than merely a psychological metaphor. Soul loss is understood as the underlying cause of a wide range of conditions: chronic depression, addictions, difficulty being fully present in one's life, a persistent sense of emptiness or incompleteness, physical illness that does not respond to ordinary treatment, and the specific quality of numbness and disconnection that follows severe trauma.

The Soul Retrieval Process

THE DIAGNOSIS: The shaman determines through their own journey or through observation that soul loss is the presenting issue — that a part of this person's soul is not in the body where it belongs.

THE JOURNEY: The shaman journeys to the non-ordinary reality where the lost soul part is located — this may be in the past (stuck at the point of the original trauma), in the lower world, or in another location accessible only through non-ordinary consciousness.

THE NEGOTIATION: The soul part may not want to come back — it left because the ordinary reality was unsafe. The shaman must communicate to the soul part that it is now safe to return, that the person is ready to receive it and to make the changes necessary to support it.

THE RETURN: The shaman brings the soul part back and blows it into the person (through the crown of the head or the chest) — literally breathing the returned soul part back into the body.

THE FOLLOW-UP: Soul retrieval without integration work is incomplete — the person needs to do the inner work necessary to welcome and sustain the returned soul part. This may involve therapy, changes in behavior, ritual practices, or other forms of support.

Spirit Animals / Power Animals

Spirit animals and power animals are among the most widely documented elements of shamanic tradition across all cultures — and also among the most frequently misunderstood or trivialized in contemporary Western popular culture. In their authentic shamanic context, they are not symbols or archetypes in the Jungian sense — they are specific spirit beings with whom the practitioner develops a working relationship, and whose presence in the practitioner's energy field provides protection, guidance, and specific medicine.

Defining the Categories

POWER ANIMAL: In core shamanic practice (following Michael Harner's synthesis from comparative research), the power animal is a specific relationship with the Oversoul of an animal species — not an individual animal and not simply any animal guide. The power animal relationship is deep, committed, and potentially lifelong. Power animals belong to the lower world and are met through lower-world shamanic journeys. A person whose power animal has left them (which can happen through trauma, disconnection from nature, or sustained spiritual neglect) may experience chronic illness, depression, or a persistent sense of diminished vitality.

SPIRIT HELPERS: Beyond the primary power animal, shamans and practitioners may work with multiple animal spirit helpers — each appearing in journeys with specific guidance, specific medicine, and specific teaching for the situation at hand. These may come and go, while the power animal relationship is sustained across years.

TOTEMS: In many traditions (particularly Native American), totem animals are clan or family animals — inherited through lineage, representing the entire group rather than the individual. The totem's medicine is the collective medicine of the people.

Power Animal Retrieval

Power animal retrieval is one of the most accessible shamanic healing ceremonies: the trained practitioner journeys to the lower world on behalf of the client, finds a power animal willing to work with that specific person, and brings it back — typically blowing it into the client through the chest or the top of the head. The client is then introduced to their power animal and taught specific practices for maintaining the relationship: feeding the animal through intention and attention, dancing the animal (embodying the animal's movement and energy in movement practice), and working with the animal in their own journeys.

The relationship with a power animal is understood as genuinely reciprocal — the animal spirit is not a servant but a partner who has its own character, its own preferences, and its own agenda in the relationship. Working with the power animal means learning to listen to what it communicates, not simply directing it toward one's own purposes.

The Shamanic Calling

Illness, Crisis, and Election

Across all shamanic traditions, the shaman does not choose their vocation — they are chosen by the spirits through specific experiences that are typically characterized by crisis, illness, or some form of breakdown. This "shamanic illness" is the initiatory ordeal through which the spirits claim the person who will serve as their conduit — and refusing the calling is understood as guaranteeing the continuation or worsening of the crisis.

INITIATORY ILLNESS: The most common form — a specific, often serious illness that defies ordinary medical explanation or treatment, which only resolves when the person accepts the shamanic vocation. In Siberian traditions, this illness is understood as the spirits dismembering the candidate (in non-ordinary reality) and reconstituting them as a shaman. In Korean Muism, the specific illness associated with the mudang calling is called sinbyeong — a specific complex of symptoms (seizures, visions, hearing voices, unusual behavior) recognized by experienced mudang as the spirits' call.

NEAR-DEATH EXPERIENCE: A serious accident, surgery, or illness that brings the person to the boundary between life and death — and in which they have specific experiences of non-ordinary reality that they bring back as evidence of the shamanic capacity.

ANCESTRAL ELECTION: Being born into a shamanic lineage — some traditions hold that shamanic ability runs in families, and that specific children are elected by the ancestral shamans before birth.

LIGHTNING STRIKE: In some traditions (Siberian, Native American), surviving a lightning strike is one of the most powerful possible signs of shamanic election — the direct contact with the sky's sacred power is understood as the spirits' most dramatic form of calling.

Siberian Shamanism

The Original Tradition

Siberia — the vast territory extending from the Ural Mountains to the Pacific Ocean across the northern half of the Asian continent — is the homeland of the shamanic tradition in its most fully documented and most archaeologically ancient form. The indigenous peoples of Siberia (the Evenki/Tungus, Yakut, Buryat, Mongolian, Nenets, Khanty, Mansi, and dozens of other distinct groups) maintained shamanic traditions of extraordinary sophistication that were documented in detail by Russian and European scholars from the 17th century onward.

THE SHAMAN'S SOCIAL ROLE: In traditional Siberian societies, the shaman was a specific category of specialist distinct from ordinary religious practitioners, healers, and community leaders. The shaman served specific functions: healing the sick (particularly soul retrieval and the removal of illness-causing spirits), divination (obtaining information from the spirits about hunting, weather, community decisions), conducting the dead to the other world (psychopomp work), and mediating between the human community and the spirit world that governs nature and fate.

THE SPIRIT WORLD STRUCTURE: Siberian shamanism maps a specific three-world cosmology (Upper World, Middle World, Lower World) connected by the World Tree or Cosmic Axis. The Upper World is the realm of the High God (Tengri — sky deity) and the celestial spirits; the Lower World is the realm of the ruler of the dead and of the earth spirits; the Middle World is where humans live alongside the spirits of nature.

THE SHAMAN'S HELPING SPIRITS: The Siberian shaman works with specific spirit helpers — typically one or more primary "mother spirits" (the shaman's primary spiritual protectors), various animal spirits, and the spirits of deceased shamans. These helpers are the shaman's extended spiritual community, without which the shamanic work is impossible.

THE ECSTATIC JOURNEY VS POSSESSION: Siberian shamanism primarily involves ecstatic journey — the shaman's spirit leaves the body to travel to other realms while the body remains accessible. This differs from the possession model (where spirits enter the shaman's body) that is more common in African diasporic traditions. Both forms occur in Siberia, but the ecstatic journey model is the defining characteristic.

Tungus and Evenki Shamanism

The Source Tradition

The Evenki (formerly called Tungus by Russian settlers) are the indigenous people across the vast territory from the Yenisei River to the Pacific Ocean — among the most mobile and most adaptable of all Siberian peoples, following the reindeer herds across thousands of kilometers of taiga and tundra. Their šaman is the etymological source of the English word "shaman," and their shamanic tradition is among the most fully documented in the ethnographic record.

The Evenki cosmic geography involves a river that flows through all three worlds — with the shaman traveling along this river to reach specific destinations. This river-based navigation of the cosmos is one of the most distinctive features of the Evenki tradition: the cosmos is not a static structure to be climbed but a flowing process to be navigated.

ONGONS (Spirit Images): The physical representations of helping spirits — small figures, typically made of leather, wood, or metal, that serve as the dwelling places of specific spirits. The Evenki shaman's collection of ongons represents their community of spirit helpers.

THE SHAMAN'S SOUL DIVISION: Evenki tradition holds that the shaman has multiple souls — unlike ordinary humans who have a single soul, the shaman's soul is divided into components that can travel independently, some remaining in the body while others journey.

THE HARGI (THE SHAMAN'S SHADOW SOUL): The specific soul component that journeys during shamanic trance — traveling through the three worlds while the shaman's body remains in the community.

HEREDITARY TRANSMISSION: Among the Evenki, shamanic ability is understood as inherited — passed through specific lineages. The spirits who worked with a deceased shaman may transfer to a descendant, choosing their new vessel from among the lineage's members.

The Siberian Shaman's Costume

A Cosmos Worn

The Siberian shaman's ceremonial costume is one of the most symbolically complete sacred garments in the world — a wearable map of the shaman's cosmic geography, a material expression of their relationships with helping spirits, and a practical instrument of shamanic work. Every element of the costume carries specific symbolic meaning; the costume as a whole constitutes the shaman's alternate body — the body they wear when moving between worlds.

THE IRON SKELETON: Many Siberian shamanic costumes are sewn with iron rings or iron plates representing the shaman's inner skeleton — the immortal iron bones that the spirits gave the shaman during the initiatory dismemberment. The Sakha/Yakut shamans of central Siberia had up to two hundred iron pendants and images attached to their leather coats.

BIRD FEATURES: Feathers, wings, and bird imagery are common throughout — the bird being the primary symbol of upper-world travel. The shaman's costume enables flight through its bird symbolism.

ANIMAL REPRESENTATIONS: Images and physical elements (claws, teeth, fur) of the shaman's primary spirit helpers — particularly the bear (earth power, healing), the eagle (upper world access, far-seeing), and various other animals specific to the shaman's helping spirit community.

MIRRORS (TOLI): Polished metal disks attached to the back of the costume — serving as armor against harmful spiritual forces (reflecting them away) and as instruments of divination (surfaces in which the spirit world can be seen).

BELLS AND JINGLES: Metal bells and jingles that sound with every movement of the costumed shaman — the sound scaring away harmful spirits and calling helping spirits to the shaman's aid.

THE HEADPIECE: A complex headdress with antlers (representing the shaman's ability to travel to the upper world) or feathers, sometimes with a face covering — the headpiece marks the shaman's transformation from ordinary human to spirit-mediator.

The Drum

The Shaman's Horse

The drum is called the shaman's horse in many Siberian traditions — the vehicle that carries the shaman on their journey between worlds. It is simultaneously the most important practical tool of shamanic work, the shaman's most sacred object, and a living being in its own right — made from the wood of the World Tree and the skin of a specific animal, containing the spirit of those materials and capable of communication with the shaman.

THE MATERIALS: The frame of the shaman's drum is traditionally made from a single piece of wood — ideally from the World Tree (the specific tree designated in the tradition as the cosmic axis), or from a tree that has been struck by lightning (a tree chosen by the sky spirits). The drumhead is made from the skin of a specific animal — deer, reindeer, elk — chosen through divination as the drum's spirit.

THE CONSTRUCTION CEREMONY: Making a shaman's drum is itself a sacred ceremony — the wood and hide are gathered with specific prayers, the drum is constructed with specific ritual, and the completed drum undergoes a consecration ceremony in which the drum is "awakened" — its spirit is called into it and the drum is introduced to the shaman's community of helping spirits.

THE DRUM AS LIVING BEING: Once consecrated, the drum is understood as a living spiritual being — not an instrument but a partner. The shaman feeds the drum (with offerings), speaks to it, and maintains a specific relationship with it. If the drum is damaged or destroyed, the shaman may become ill.

THE DRUMMING PATTERN: The Siberian shamanic drumbeat is typically in the range of 4-7 beats per second — a frequency that research has shown to facilitate the specific theta-wave states of consciousness in which shamanic journeying occurs. The drum is beaten throughout the journey, maintaining the specific state of consciousness that makes navigation of non-ordinary reality possible.

Yakut and Buryat Shamanism

Beyond the Evenki, two of the most significant and most extensively documented Siberian shamanic traditions are those of the Yakut (Sakha) people and the Buryat people — each representing a distinct regional expression of the pan-Siberian shamanic pattern with its own specific cosmological features, spirit categories, and ceremonial forms.

Yakut (Sakha) Shamanism

The Yakut or Sakha people inhabit the Sakha Republic (Yakutia) in northeastern Siberia — one of the coldest inhabited regions on earth, with winter temperatures reaching -60°C. Their shamanic tradition, practiced by the *oyuun* (shaman), reflects this extreme environment: the spirits of cold, of the forest, and of the sky are particularly powerful, and the shaman's capacity to navigate these forces is existentially critical to the community.

Yakut cosmology integrates a distinctive role for horses and fire: the horse (a sacred animal of great prestige among the Yakut) appears in shamanic cosmology as both spirit helper and cosmic vehicle, and the *Yhyakh* festival — the major annual celebration honoring the rebirth of nature — centers on ritual libations of *koumiss* (fermented mare's milk) and communal ceremony involving the sun, fire, and the blessing of the community by the spirits. The Yakut shaman's costume, like that of other Siberian traditions, encodes the shaman's spirit relationships — including the characteristic iron plates and antler headdress — but with specific Yakut forms and animals reflecting the local sacred geography.

Buryat Shamanism

The Buryat people — closely related to Mongolian culture and inhabiting the region around Lake Baikal — represent one of the most complex cases of shamanic tradition in Siberia: a tradition deeply influenced by Tibetan Buddhism (introduced from the south) while retaining its indigenous shamanic core. The Buryat shaman (called *boo*) works within a cosmological framework that includes both the traditional three-world structure and Buddhist-influenced elements — deities, protective spirits, and ceremonial forms that blend the two traditions.

Buryat cosmology features the *tnгри* — sky spirits that parallel the Mongolian tradition of 99 *Tengri* (sky beings), including the specific hierarchy of benevolent and wrathful deities who govern different domains of life. Lake Baikal, the world's deepest and oldest freshwater lake, is among the most sacred geographic features of the Buryat world — home to powerful water spirits and a point of particular sacred potency. Following the collapse of the Soviet Union (which had severely suppressed Siberian shamanism), Buryatia experienced a significant revival of traditional shamanic practice, with shamanic associations forming, public ceremonies resuming, and younger generations taking up the tradition.

Mongolian Shamanism

Tengerism — The Eternal Blue Sky

Mongolian shamanism — also called Tengerism (from Tengri, the Eternal Blue Sky) — is one of the world's oldest and most historically significant shamanic traditions, having shaped the spiritual cosmology of the Mongol Empire that once stretched from Korea to Hungary. The Mongolian shaman (böö for males, udgan for females) serves as the axis between worlds, the one who speaks to the spirits when no one else can, who rides the drum like a horse and crosses the invisible realms of sky, earth, and underworld.

Tengri — The Eternal Blue Sky

Tengri (the Eternal Blue Sky) is the supreme deity of Tengerism — not a personal god in the Western sense but the sky itself: the infinite, eternal, all-encompassing blue expanse above. Tengri is the source of all cosmic order, divine mandate, and life force. Genghis Khan (c. 1162-1227) was a devoted Tengrist — the phrase "the force of the Eternal Sky" (mönkh tengerin küchin) appears repeatedly in the Secret History of the Mongols (c. 1240), and his conquests were understood as cosmically ordained by Tengri. This concept of heaven-mandated rulership influenced Chinese imperial ideology throughout the region.

The Tengri Spirit Hierarchy

Mongolian cosmology describes three interconnected worlds: the Upper World (Tengri's realm) containing 99 tenger (sky spirits), including the sun, moon, stars, and celestial deities; the Middle World where humans, animals, and nature spirits dwell; and the Lower World (Erlig Khan's realm), the underworld home of ancestors, earth spirits, and darker forces. The 99 tenger are organized in hierarchies, with Qormusta Tengri (King of the Gods) at the apex. Ancestor spirits, the spirits of mountains and rivers, and the spirits of historical heroes all populate the Mongolian shamanic world.

Mongolian Shamanic Practice

The Mongolian shaman works through specific ceremonies that invoke and negotiate with these spirits — using the drum, offerings, and ritual dress that encodes the shaman's spirit relationships. The ovoo (a sacred stone cairn) is the most ubiquitous ritual object in the Mongolian landscape — a marker of sacred place where offerings are made and where the spirits of the location are honored. Following the Soviet era (during which shamanism was outlawed and drums burned), Mongolian shamanism has experienced a significant post-Soviet revival, with shaman associations proliferating, ceremonies resuming in public, and the tradition being reclaimed as a central element of Mongolian national identity. Tengerism is today practiced in Mongolia, Kyrgyzstan, Kazakhstan, Sakha, Buryatia, Tuva, and Turkey.

South American Shamanism

The Plant Teachers

South American shamanism — particularly the traditions of the Amazon Basin, the Andes, and the Amazon's tributaries — represents the world's most sophisticated and most fully developed tradition of plant-medicine-based healing and consciousness exploration. These traditions have developed over thousands of years a specific technology: the use of specific plant medicines (understood as teachers and allies, not as drugs or recreational substances) as the primary vehicle for accessing non-ordinary reality, receiving healing, and navigating the spirit world.

The foundational distinction between South American shamanic plant traditions and all other approaches to psychoactive plants is this: in the Amazonian tradition, the plants are not drugs that produce effects — they are teachers who have specific knowledge to transmit to the practitioner who approaches them correctly.

AYAHUASCA (*Banisteriopsis caapi* + *Psychotria viridis*): The "vine of souls" — a brew combining the ayahuasca vine (which contains MAO inhibitors) and the chacruna leaf (which contains DMT). The combination produces a 4-8 hour visionary state of extraordinary depth and intensity. Used primarily for healing — physical, psychological, and spiritual — and for receiving guidance from the plant teacher.

HUACHUMA / SAN PEDRO (*Echinopsis pachanoi*): The Andean sacred cactus — containing mescaline, used in ceremony by the curanderos of the Andes for at least 3,000 years. Where ayahuasca tends toward the interior and the dark, huachuma tends toward the exterior and the light — often described as opening the heart and expanding perception of the ordinary world's sacred nature.

TOBACCO (*Mapacho*): The most sacred plant in the Amazon — not the commercial tobacco of cigarettes, but the dark Amazonian mapacho (*Nicotiana rustica*) used in ceremonial context. The curandero uses tobacco to open the ceremonial space, to call the spirits, and to conduct the healing work.

THE DIETA: Before working with plant teachers, the Amazonian practitioner undertakes a dieta — a period of dietary and behavioral restriction (avoiding salt, sugar, alcohol, meat, sex) that opens the practitioner's sensitivity to the plant's teaching. The dieta is not preparation for the ceremony; it IS the ceremony, with the ingestion of the plant as a concentrated event within a longer process.

Shipibo Curanderismo

Song as Healing Technology

The Shipibo-Conibo people of the Peruvian Amazon have developed what may be the world's most sophisticated tradition of song-based healing — a tradition in which the curandero (healer) perceives the spiritual patterns underlying physical and psychological illness as visual geometric forms (kene — the Shipibo sacred design system) and corrects those patterns through specific songs (icaros).

Shipibo healers perceive the human body as covered with a specific geometric pattern — a luminous design (kene) that represents the person's spiritual health. When all is well, the pattern is clear, symmetrical, and vibrant. When illness is present, specific portions of the pattern are distorted, dark, or absent. The curandero's task is to perceive the distortion and correct it through the appropriate song.

THE MALOCA (CEREMONIAL HOUSE): Traditional ayahuasca ceremonies are conducted in specific structures — the maloca, a large open structure with a central fire and specific spatial organization.

THE ONANYA (MASTER HEALER): The most senior Shipibo healer — one who has undergone years of dieta with specific plant teachers, has developed a personal relationship with multiple plant spirits, and can perceive and work with the kene patterns of illness and health.

THE MERAYA: An even higher level of Shipibo healer — one who can transform into specific animals and whose healing capacity extends to the most severe conditions. The meraya tradition is endangered; very few living practitioners are recognized at this level.

THE CEREMONY STRUCTURE: The ceremony begins after dark — the Onanya ingests ayahuasca, waits for the specific visionary state to arise, and then begins singing the icaros that the ceremony requires. At specific moments, the curandero comes to each participant and sings specific icaros directly to them — the specific song being chosen by what the curandero perceives of that person's spiritual pattern.

The Icaros

Sacred Songs of the Amazon

Icaros are the sacred healing songs of Amazonian curanderismo — received from the plant spirits through sustained relationship during the dieta process, sung during ceremony to call specific spirits, to open and close the ceremonial space, to guide the participants' visionary experience, and to effect specific healings. They are simultaneously the primary tool of the healer's work and evidence of the healer's relationship with the spirit world.

Icaros are not composed in the ordinary sense — a curandero does not sit down and write healing songs. They are received: during extended dieta with specific plant teachers, the plants sing their songs to the practitioner in dreams, in visions, and in the specific states of consciousness that the dieta process opens. A curandero's repertoire of icaros represents their community of plant-spirit allies — each icaro is the voice of a specific plant spirit.

Ayahuasca

The Vine of Souls

Ayahuasca (Quechua — "vine of the soul" or "vine of the dead") is the sacred plant medicine of the Amazon Basin — a brew combining the *Banisteriopsis caapi* vine (which contains MAO inhibitors: harmine, harmaline, and tetrahydroharmine) and the *Psychotria viridis* leaf (which contains DMT — N,N-dimethyltryptamine). The combination produces a 4-8 hour state of intensified consciousness with profound visionary content that has been used by Amazonian peoples for healing, divination, and spiritual development for at least two thousand years.

The biochemical sophistication of the ayahuasca combination deserves specific acknowledgment: DMT alone is not orally active because the body's monoamine oxidase (MAO) enzymes break it down before it reaches the brain. The MAO inhibitors in the *Banisteriopsis caapi* vine prevent this breakdown, allowing the DMT in the *Psychotria viridis* leaves to become orally active. The specific combination of these two plants — among thousands of Amazonian plant species — to produce a specific desired effect suggests either extraordinary systematic experimentation or exactly what the tradition claims: the plants told the people how to combine them.

NOT A RECREATIONAL SUBSTANCE: The most important thing to understand about ayahuasca in its traditional context is that it is not used recreationally or for psychological exploration in the Western therapeutic sense. It is a sacred medicine used in a sacred context (ceremony, with a trained healer, with specific spiritual preparation) for specific healing purposes. The Western "ayahuasca tourism" that has developed around it often strips away the sacred context and the trained guidance that make the tradition both safe and effective.

THE PURGE: Ayahuasca typically produces vomiting (the "purga" — purge) that is understood in the tradition not as a side effect to be managed but as a sacred component of the healing — the physical expulsion of illness, trauma, and spiritual debris from the body.

THE MAREACIÓN (THE STATE): The specific state of consciousness produced by ayahuasca is called mareación — typically including intense visual content, heightened emotional sensitivity, access to memories and patterns not ordinarily available to consciousness, and the specific quality of the plant teacher's presence as a guiding intelligence in the experience.

RISKS: Ayahuasca in inappropriate contexts (without trained guidance, without proper preparation, in combination with contraindicated medications, or with people with certain psychological conditions) carries genuine risks. Responsible engagement requires proper preparation, proper context, and proper guidance.

The Andean Tradition

Paqos, Apus, and the Living Cosmos

The Andean shamanic tradition — practiced by the indigenous peoples of the Andes mountains in Peru, Bolivia, Ecuador, and neighboring regions — is one of the most sophisticated and most complete shamanic systems in South America. The Andean tradition is organized around the concept of Pachamama (Mother Earth) and the Apus (mountain spirits — each major Andean mountain is a specific spiritual being with its own character, its own domain, and its own relationship with the human communities living in its vicinity).

THE PAQO: The Andean spiritual practitioner — working with the energies of the natural world, with the Apus, and with Pachamama to heal, to guide, to maintain right relationship between the human community and the living cosmos.

AYNI (SACRED RECIPROCITY): The foundational principle of Andean practice — the reciprocal exchange of energy between human beings and the natural world, between the practitioner and their helping spirits, between the individual and the community. Every offering, every healing, every ceremony is an act of ayni.

THE DESPACHO: The primary Andean offering ceremony — a complex, beautiful arrangement of symbolic objects (flowers, seeds, sweets, llama fat, shells, coca leaves, and dozens of other items) assembled with specific prayers and intentions, wrapped in paper, and offered to Pachamama and the Apus through burning or burying. The despacho is simultaneously a prayer, an offering, and a sacred art form.

THE COCA LEAF: The most sacred plant in the Andean tradition — used for divination, for prayer, for the despacho, and for direct communication with the spirits. The specific way the practitioner blows their prayers into the coca leaf (phukuy) before offering it is the Andean equivalent of the prayer-charged sound-vibration in other traditions.

THE APUS: The specific mountain spirits are some of the most powerful sacred beings in the Andean tradition. Each major Apu has its own personality — some accessible and friendly, some demanding and fierce. Working with a specific Apu requires building a relationship over time through offerings and proper conduct.

Huachuma / San Pedro

The Grandfather Cactus

Huachuma (known in Spanish as San Pedro — Saint Peter, "he who holds the keys to heaven") is the sacred columnar cactus of the Andes (*Echinopsis pachanoi*), used in ceremony by Andean peoples for at least 3,000 years, with archaeological evidence suggesting ceremonial use extending back as far as 8,000 years in the Peruvian highlands. The Chavin culture (whose temple site Chavin de Huantar, dated to approximately 900-200 BCE, shows clear evidence of huachuma use in ceremony) established the tradition that runs continuously to the present day through Andean curanderos.

Huachuma contains mescaline as its primary active alkaloid — the same compound found in peyote, though Andean practitioners understand the two medicines as distinct teachers with different characters. As one traditional teacher described: "Huachuma and Peyote are spiritual brothers but not twins. Peyote is like a hammer. It's a beautiful hammer, though. Huachuma is like a feather. But it's a heavy, heavy feather." The effect of huachuma is understood by practitioners as heart-opening, exterior, and light — where ayahuasca tends toward interior depth and intensity, huachuma tends toward expanded perception of the ordinary world's sacred character.

The Huachuma Mesa Ceremony

Traditional huachuma ceremony is conducted by a curandero (in the Andean context sometimes called a yachakkuna or maestro) and centers on the mesa — a ceremonial altar in the shape of an Andean cross (the Chakana), containing energetically-charged objects arranged according to the principles of Andean cosmology. The mesa is the practitioner's primary sacred tool, encoding their specific relationships with the spirit world and the specific medicines they work with.

The ceremony begins with the preparation and ingestion of huachuma tea (brewed from the outer green skin of the cactus, which contains the highest concentration of mescaline). The onset takes approximately one hour; the ceremony lasts 12-14 hours — significantly longer than ayahuasca. During this extended time, the curandero works with the participants using the mesa and specific ritual tools — tobacco, incense, sacred objects — to focus and direct the medicine's healing work. Many participants report meeting spirit guides, ancestors, and other beings; experiencing profound emotional clarity; and perceiving the sacred intelligence that, in the Andean view, inhabits all of nature. Huachuma's traditional use was for healing, divination, and direct communication with the Apus and Pachamama — the medicine was understood as a vehicle that transported the practitioner into direct relationship with the living cosmos.

Korean Muism

The Female Shamanic Tradition

Korean Muism (무속 — Musok, the way of the mu) is one of the world's oldest continuous shamanic traditions — a living, fully active sacred tradition practiced by thousands of mudang (female shamans, the primary practitioners) throughout contemporary Korea. Unlike the Siberian traditions that have been severely disrupted by Soviet policies and the South American traditions that are endangered by cultural change, Korean Muism has maintained remarkable continuity and is currently experiencing a significant revival among younger Koreans seeking connection with their indigenous sacred heritage.

Archaeological evidence suggests shamanic practice in the Korean peninsula extending back at least 4,000 years — bronze mirrors, shaman drums, and ritual objects found in ancient burial sites are consistent with the shamanic practices documented in contemporary Muism. The tradition predates Buddhism (introduced to Korea in the 4th century CE) and Confucianism and has survived the sustained pressure of both.

FEMALE DOMINATED: While male shamans (baksu mudang) exist, the overwhelming majority of Korean shamanic practitioners are women. This female dominance is one of the most distinctive features of Muism.

URBAN PRESENCE: Korean Muism is not only a rural folk tradition — it is practiced in Seoul and other major Korean cities, serving urbanized populations with the same traditional ceremonies that served agricultural communities centuries ago.

POSSESSION MODEL: Where Siberian shamanism primarily involves ecstatic journey (the shaman's spirit travels to other worlds), Korean Muism primarily involves possession — the spirits enter the mudang's body, and the mudang speaks and acts as the spirit during the ceremony.

PRACTICAL ORIENTATION: Korean Muism is remarkably practical — people consult mudang for specific, concrete problems: illness, business decisions, family conflicts, the needs of deceased ancestors. The mudang provides specific guidance from the spirits, not general spiritual counsel.

THE FIVE THOUSAND SPIRITS: The Korean shamanic spirit world is organized around a vast assembly of specific named spirits — divine generals, nature spirits, ancestral spirits, spirits of the dead — all of whom may be called upon and may speak through the mudang in ceremony.

The Mudang

Korea's Female Shamans

The mudang is the Korean female shaman — the specialist practitioner of Muism who has been called by the spirits (through sinbyeong — the shamanic illness), has undergone initiation (naerimsut), and serves as the primary mediator between the human community and the Korean spirit world. The mudang is simultaneously a healer, a diviner, an entertainer (in the traditional sense — one who maintains relationships), and a priest.

SINBYEONG (THE SPIRIT SICKNESS): The shamanic calling in Korean tradition manifests as sinbyeong — a specific complex of symptoms: physical illness (often severe), psychological disturbance (auditory and visual phenomena, altered states), social withdrawal, and distinctive behavior that experienced mudang recognize as the spirits' claim on the person.

NAERIMSUT (THE INITIATION CEREMONY): The ceremony through which the calling is confirmed and accepted — lasting several days, involving the descent of the specific spirits who will become the mudang's primary working spirits, the formal recognition of the new mudang by the community, and the establishment of the specific spirit relationships that will define the mudang's practice.

THE SPIRIT MOTHER/GRANDMOTHER: Every mudang has a specific senior mudang who serves as their teacher and spiritual mother — the one who guided them through sinbyeong, conducted their naerimsut, and continues to guide their development. This lineage relationship is essential to the legitimacy of the mudang's practice.

THE MUDANG'S COSTUME: Like the Siberian shaman's costume, the mudang wears specific ceremonial dress for each spirit they embody during ceremony — changing costumes multiple times in the course of a gut (the full Korean shamanic ceremony). Each costume is specific to a specific spirit.

THE MUDANG'S INSTRUMENTS: The jangu (hourglass drum), the buk (barrel drum), the jing (large gong), the kkwaenggari (small hand gong) — each instrument associated with specific spirits and specific ceremonial functions.

The Gut

The Korean Shamanic Ceremony

The gut (굿) is the Korean shamanic ceremony — the formal gathering of the mudang and the community for the specific purpose of communicating with the spirits, seeking their guidance or healing, and maintaining right relationship between the human and spirit worlds. A full gut is an extended event lasting from several hours to several days, involving multiple ceremonies (gori) that each call specific spirits.

THE PREPARATION: Before the gut begins, the mudang prepares the ceremonial space — setting up specific altars (jed0) for each category of spirit to be called, arranging specific foods and offerings appropriate to each spirit, and conducting preparatory prayer.

THE BUJEONG (PURIFICATION): The opening ceremony — purifying the ceremonial space and the participants of any harmful energies or influences that might interfere with the spirit communication.

THE SEQUENTIAL CALLING (GORI BY GORI): The gut proceeds through a specific sequence of ceremonies (gori), each calling a different category of spirit — the guardian general spirits (Sinjang), the household protective spirits, the specific ancestral spirits of the family commissioning the gut, and the specific spirits whose involvement is required for the gut's specific purpose.

THE POSSESSION: As each spirit is called through drumming, music, and specific invocation songs, the spirit descends into the mudang's body. The mudang's posture, voice, and behavior change completely — the spirit speaks through the mudang directly to the community.

THE ORACLES: The possessed mudang speaks as the spirit — providing specific guidance, revealing the spiritual causes of the client's problems, and prescribing specific remedies (ritual actions, offerings, behavioral changes).

THE HUMOR: One of the most distinctive features of Korean gut ceremonies is their humor — the spirits, particularly the household guardian spirits, are often comically irreverent, making jokes, teasing the community, and creating laughter as part of the sacred ceremony. This integration of comedy and the sacred is one of Korean Muism's most distinctive characteristics.

The Spirits of Korean Muism

The Korean shamanic spirit world — the vast assembly the source documents describe as the "Five Thousand Spirits" — is not a random collection but a structured cosmological map of sacred forces organized by category, function, and domain. Every major spirit category has specific characteristics, specific demands, specific offerings, and specific ceremonial forms for invocation and communication.

The Major Spirit Categories

SINJANG (DIVINE GENERALS): Military general spirits are among the most important and most frequently called spirits in Korean Muism. They include the Obang Changgun (Generals of the Five Directions), figures from Korean military history like Choe Yeong and Im Gyeong-eop, and even (in some communities near Incheon) General Douglas MacArthur as a hero of the Korean War — demonstrating the tradition's capacity to absorb and integrate historical figures into the spirit world. The Sinjang are protective, powerful, and demanding — their ceremonies are often the most theatrical and physically intense of the gut.

JOSANG (ANCESTRAL SPIRITS): The spirits of deceased family members who remain in active relationship with their living descendants. Ancestral spirits are honored through specific ceremonies within the gut and through regular household ritual. When ancestral relationships become strained — through unresolved grief, unfulfilled obligations, or the ancestor's unresolved emotional state at the time of death — family problems, illness, and misfortune may follow, requiring specific ceremony to restore the relationship.

SANSHIN (MOUNTAIN SPIRITS): The spirits of specific mountains — depicted as elderly white-bearded sages accompanied by tigers, resident in small shrines behind Buddhist temples and in mountain areas throughout Korea. The mountain spirit is one of the most beloved and most widely venerated spirits in Korean sacred life, representing wisdom, long life, and the protective power of the sacred landscape.

YONGWANG (DRAGON KINGS): The spirits of the sea, rivers, and lakes — powerful beings who govern weather, fishing, and travel across water. Coastal and riverine communities maintain active relationships with the Yongwang through specific ceremonies, particularly before fishing expeditions.

HOUSEHOLD SPIRITS (SEONGJU AND OTHERS): The spirits of the house itself — the spirit of the main post of the house (Seongju), the spirit of the threshold, the spirit of the kitchen. These household spirits are the most intimate and most constantly present spirits in everyday Korean sacred life, honored through specific domestic practices and ceremonies.

SPIRITS OF THE DEAD (GWISIN): Those who have died without completing their proper transition to the ancestral realm — typically those who died violently, prematurely, or without the proper funeral ceremonies. The gwisin may wander, causing disturbance, until specific ceremony is performed to help them complete their transition. Much of the mudang's practical work addresses these wandering spirits on behalf of families affected by their presence.

Soul Retrieval Across Traditions

A Comparative Map

Soul loss — the condition in which a part of the soul has separated from the whole due to trauma, shock, or extreme distress — and soul retrieval — the shamanic technology for recovering what has been lost — appear across virtually every shamanic tradition in the world with remarkable consistency.

SIBERIAN TRADITION: Diagnosis: The shaman perceives the missing soul-part through divination and/or journey. Method: The shaman journeys to the non-ordinary reality where the soul-part is located, negotiates its return, and brings it back — blowing it into the patient through the crown or the chest.

SOUTH AMERICAN (SHIPIBO/AMAZON): Diagnosis: The curandero perceives the distortion in the patient's kene (luminous body pattern) that indicates soul loss. Method: During the ayahuasca ceremony, the curandero uses specific icaros to call the lost soul-part back and to restore the kene to its proper pattern.

KOREAN MUISM: Diagnosis: A gut reveals through spirit communication that a family member's illness or misfortune is related to soul loss (holligi — the soul being "snatched"). Method: A specific ceremony calls the lost soul back — the mudang may physically go to the location of the traumatic event (or its spiritual equivalent) to retrieve the soul and bring it home. The Communal Dimension: Korean soul retrieval ceremonies often involve the entire family gathering to welcome the returned soul-part back.

The Haligric Ancestor Altar and Shamanic Practice

The Living Altar Concept

The Haligric concept of the Living Altar — an altar oriented toward the living versions of the self and loved ones across simultaneous time, drawing on shamanic soul retrieval concepts, Yoruba/Kemetic veneration, Jungian inner child work, and quantum non-locality — finds its most direct ancient parallels in shamanic soul retrieval practice across all three traditions covered in this guide. The foundational shamanic recognition — that the soul is not a fixed, unified, continuous thing but a fluid, multiple, recoverable energy that can be lost through trauma and retrieved through specific sacred work — is the metaphysical basis of the Living Altar concept.

SIBERIAN PARALLEL: The Evenki ongon (spirit figure) maintained as a dwelling place for specific helping spirits parallels the Living Altar's function as a material locus of sacred relationship. The ongon invites and sustains the spirit's presence in the ordinary world; the Living Altar invites and sustains the soul-dimensions of the self across time.

SHIPIBO PARALLEL: The Shipibo curandero's work of perceiving and restoring the kene (luminous body pattern) parallels the Living Altar's work of acknowledging and honoring the whole-pattern of the self — including the parts that may have fragmented through trauma.

KOREAN PARALLEL: The Korean gut ceremony's work of calling back souls that have been "snatched" by illness, shock, or death parallels the Living Altar's practice of calling back and welcoming the aspects of self that may have withdrawn from full participation in the present.

THE SPECIFIC HALIGRIC CONTRIBUTION: The Living Altar innovates by orienting not backward to deceased ancestors (as most ancestor altars do) but across simultaneous time — acknowledging and honoring the past self (who survived what was survived), the present self (who is doing this work), the future self (who has already arrived at what is being worked toward), and the inner divine self (the deepest eternal nature).

The Haligricity Lens

Non-Ordinary Reality and the Living Altar

Shamanism's specific and irreplaceable contribution to Haligricity is the most ancient and most practically tested available map of the soul's structure and the soul's healing. Every other tradition in the Haligricity library approaches the divine from specific cultural, philosophical, or theological angles; shamanism approaches the sacred from the angle of direct technical work with the soul's condition — the oldest available clinical approach to the spiritual dimension of human wellbeing.

The Three Traditions' Complementary Gifts

Siberian shamanism provides the most complete cartography of the three-world structure and the mechanics of shamanic journey — the map of non-ordinary reality that every other shamanic tradition uses in some form. South American shamanism provides the most sophisticated ancient tradition of plant-assisted healing — the recognition that specific plants are teachers whose specific intelligence can assist in healing that no human practitioner's skill alone can accomplish. Korean Muism provides the most socially integrated and most continuously practiced model of community shamanic ceremony — demonstrating that shamanic practice can be fully incorporated into the ordinary social fabric of a modern nation without losing its essential sacred character.

The Drum and the Varessence

The shamanic drum — the primary technology for inducing the specific state of consciousness in which soul retrieval, spirit communication, and healing work become possible — is the most ancient available parallel to the Haligric understanding of sound as a transformative technology. The specific drumbeat frequency (4-7 beats per second) that induces theta-wave states is the operative mechanism; the sacred frame within which the drumming occurs (the intention, the ceremony, the helping spirits) is what makes the sound sacred rather than merely rhythmic. The Varessence operates on the same principle: the sound is charged by the quality of consciousness brought to it, and that quality of consciousness creates the conditions for transformation that the sound alone cannot produce.

*"The shaman knows that the world is alive.
Everything is alive. Everything is conscious.
Everything is willing to communicate
with the being who approaches it in the right way."*

— Teaching of multiple shamanic traditions

The drum beats 200 times per minute and the brain shifts into the frequency where the other worlds become visible. The icaro rises from the healer's throat and the luminous pattern of the patient's body begins to correct itself. The mudang's eyes roll back and the grandmother spirit speaks through her mouth to the family that has been waiting for thirty years to hear what she has to say. These are the oldest technologies. They work.
Grand Rising.